

FOR POLITICAL TRPs

TAMIL NADU

JAYA TV: Owned by AIADMK chief Jayalalithaa.

SUN TV, SUN NEWS, KTV, SUN MUSIC, CHUTTI TV (FOR KIDS): Promoted by Kalanidhi Maran, Karunanidhi's grandnephew. However, the channel fell off DMK's radar after Kalanidhi's brother Dayanidhi was sacked from the Union Cabinet.

RAJ TV, RAJ DIGITAL PLUS: Owned by Raajendaran, a businessman, who is now considered close to DMK.

KALAINGNAR TV: Promoted by Karunanidhi, the DMK patriarch.

MAKKAL TV: Promoted by PMK chief S. Ramadoss, father of Union Minister Anbumani Ramadoss.

VASANTH TV: A news and entertainment channel owned by H. Vasathakumar, MLA and president, Tamil Nadu commerce wing of Congress. Still to be launched.

MEGA TV: Owned by K.V. Thangabalu, a Congress MP and ex-Union minister. Still to be launched.

KERALA

KAIRALI TV, PEOPLE TV:

Promoted by Malayalam Communications, a company owned by CPI(M).

JAI HIND TV: Pro-Congress channel financed by Malayalee NRIs.

INDIAVISION: Owned by M.K. Muneer, former Muslim League minister.

KARNATAKA

KANNADA KASTURI:

Launched by Anita Kumaraswamy, former chief minister H.D. Kumaraswamy's wife.



they both claim.

"It's political capitalism making its first moves in the electronic media. South Indian politicians seem to be following what is happening in some parts of the world where politicians and political parties own media houses a la Silvio Berlusconi of Italy or Thaksin Shinawatra of Thailand," says Sashi Kumar, director of Chennai's Asian School of Journalism and founder of Asianet, the most successful Malayalam channel. Though most of the channels are aligned to political

parties, their content mix is more or less similar: songs, dances, soaps, film-based programmes and in keeping with the latest trend, SMS-based reality shows. Where they differ is in their treatment of news and current affairs. Try as much as they can, they can't hide the slant towards their respective political parties.

Take the case of Tamil Nadu, where popular cinema and its actors have traditionally dominated politics.

LEAD KINDLY LIGHT: Congress plans to launch channel in every language



The state showed the way back in 1992 when Karunanidhi's grandnephew Kalanidhi Maran started the Sun TV Network. As Sun TV gained a stranglehold over the state's television viewers, Jayalalithaa and her associates launched JJ TV which was later rechristened Jaya TV. But after Karunanidhi fell out with Dayanidhi, Kalanidhi's brother, DMK had no option but to launch its own channel to fight both the 20-channel Sun TV Network and Jaya TV. "Sun TV used its phenomenal success in entertainment programmes to carry DMK's political messages till the recent split," says Sreedhar Ramanujam, CEO, Integrated Brandcomm.

For Kumaraswamy, who is a film producer, it was only natural to jump into the world of television. Though Kannada Kasturi would be the tenth TV channel in the language, it is the first to be owned and operated by a *mannina maga* (son of the soil), which is going to be a major advantage, feels media watcher Vasanth T.P. Right now, almost all the Kannada channels are owned by non-Kannadigas. Anita wants the Rs 50-crore channel to be a mix of news, education and entertainment. News will form just 40 per cent of the programming content.